A NEW LOW FOR INDIA...

India's route to the FIFA World Cup lies through Asian qualifiers. But the national team did not even qualify for the top pan-Asian tournament, the quadrennial AFC Asian Cup, from 1992-2007 and in 2015 and 2027, making it only in the 2011, 2019 and 2023 versions

INDIA AT THE AFC ASIAN CUP TOURNAMENT

2011

Teams	Matches	Wins	Draws	Losses
16	3	0	0	3

2019

Teams	Matches	Wins	Draws	Losses
24	3	1	0	2

2023

Teams	Matches	Wins	Draws	Losses
24	3	0	0	3

2026 WORLD CUP QUALIFIERS

AFC 2ND ROUND*

Teams	Matches	Wins	Draws	Losses
4	6	1	2	3

November 2023 to June 2024

AFC 3RD ROUND**

Teams	Matches	Wins	Draws	Losses
4	6	1	2	3

September 2024-June 2025

**Competing in a group featuring Qatar, Kuwait and Afghanistan, India finished third. It was thus out of contention for the FIFA World Cup qualification, but had a chance to qualify for the AFC Asian Cup*

***Competing in a group featuring Singapore, Hong Kong and Bangladesh, India finished last and failed to qualify for the AFC Asian Cup 2027 as well*



AFP

cricketers earning in crores.

Compared with Europe's elite competitions like the Premier League (England), La Liga (Spain), Bundesliga (Germany) and Serie A (Italy), Indian football is in a developmental phase. These leagues are backed by rich clubs, world-class academies and scouting systems, multi-billion-dollar broadcast deals and deep talent pools, enabling them to attract the world's best players and coaches. Indian football, by contrast, is still stuck at building its grassroots ecosystem and infrastructure.

CATCH THEM YOUNG

Those involved in Indian football insist that the country's biggest failure begins long before players wear the blue jersey. "Kids do not have access to sport...there's a shortage of grounds for football," says Pradhyum Reddy, former head coach of Shillong Lajong FC and erstwhile CEO of Dempo FC. "It's not just about training at academies; you need to have leagues that run all year around for youth."

India depends on youngsters presenting themselves for selection trials instead of building a nationwide scouting network. In a country where football largely remains a working-class sport, experts argue that expecting a daily wage earner from the rural areas to send his child to a metropolis in the hope of being spotted is unrealistic. "Scouting must be spread across districts and villages, where youngsters are constantly assessed and monitored," argues Anirban Dutta, secretary of the Indian Football Association—the apex football body in West Bengal.

Indeed, the years between childhood and late adolescence determine whether a footballer acquires the technical ability, tactical intelligence and physical conditioning required for the modern game. Yet India has only a handful of noteworthy residential football academies, like Minerva in Chandigarh, where such skills are best honed. In nations like Spain and the UK, promising players grow up in academies that integrate schooling with sports science, psychology, recovery—even position-specific coaching.

If India aspires to be at the World Cup in the next decade, it needs to focus hard on youth development. Many believe foreign expertise would deliver greater returns if deployed at the youth level, where coaches can shape muscle memory and tactical awareness. "Our youth structure is the foundation, and that is where we have failed," says Bengal football team coach Sanjoy Sen.

However, even the best coaching cannot compensate for the absence of competitive football. Indian professionals play only around 30 competitive matches in a season, with few overseas matches. Most foreign players play over 50 matches in domestic leagues and international tournaments.

The countries now racing ahead of India have spent decades correcting precisely these structural weaknesses. Japan laid the foundations of its modern football ecosystem three decades ago through the J-League, linking every professional club to a robust academy system. Uzbekistan, too, invested systematically in school football.